Cover letter draft

Dear Editors,

Please consider my Original Research manuscript, "Apparent Performance under Selective Environmental Risk: Strategic Acceptance and Reputation under a Zero-Effect Rainfall Null," for publication in *Risk Analysis*.

The manuscript addresses a general problem in performance evaluation: when baseline environmental hazard is heterogeneous and providers can select their exposure to that risk, raw observed performance may reflect risk composition and selective acceptance rather than causal provider performance. The untreated counterfactual is unobserved, so the components cannot be separated by outcome rates alone.

The study uses rainmaking as a deliberately sharp known-ground-truth stress test in which the intervention's causal effect on rainfall is fixed exactly at zero. Because true efficacy is not ambiguous, apparent performance generated by baseline hazard, selective exposure, attribution, and learning can be measured directly. Using archived ERA5 rainfall at 8 contrasting rainfall regimes, I show that selective acceptance can materially raise apparent performance without changing rainfall: seven-day apparent success ranges from 0.593 under random drought timing to 0.853 under high prospective hazard.

A second result concerns dynamics. Past attributed outcomes accumulate into a provider-specific reputation stock, whereas current apparent performance remains a flow governed by current environmental hazard. Reputation and price premia therefore need not imply superior contemporaneous performance; in the simulation the contemporaneous price-success association is negative even while premia persist.

The paper separates each component—baseline hazard, endogenous demand, selective acceptance, attribution, and reputation learning—through a staged Monte Carlo decomposition, and stress-tests the conclusions across thresholds, parameters, replication counts, and a pre-specified permutation falsification. Willingness-to-pay and price results are presented as calibrated and simulated consequences of attributed performance, not as historical estimates, and the positive contemporaneous price-success proposition is explicitly reported as unsupported.

I believe this question sits within the scope of *Risk Analysis*: performance inference under heterogeneous risk, selective exposure, hidden counterfactuals, risk adjustment, reputation, and decision-making under uncertainty. Espín-Sánchez, Gil-Guirado, and Ryan establish the rain-prayer timing, hazard, and persuasion foundation and its historical evidence; this manuscript asks a different risk-analysis question—what raw provider performance means once requests, selective acceptance, provider-specific reputation, and risk-conditioned outcomes are separated. The practical implication is restrained but consequential: raw performance measures may reward favorable exposure rather than causal improvement, which motivates prospective risk adjustment and disclosure of rejected cases as candidate safeguards for provider scorecards and performance contracts.

[AUTHOR CONFIRMATION REQUIRED: The manuscript is original and is not under consideration elsewhere.] It uses no human participants or confidential data. All redistributable analytical inputs, code, acquisition records, checksums, simulation outputs, and manuscript values accompany the submission; exact retrieval records are supplied for audit sources that are not redistributed.

[AUTHOR INPUT REQUIRED: corresponding author name, affiliation, contact details, funding, competing interests, acknowledgements, and any suggested reviewers.]

Sincerely,

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